variability and difficulty of tracks and terrain encountered on the way make this an optimistic estimate.

While within cities like Ujjayini, where Ashoka was headed, all-weather roads were constructed with a veneer of gravel over a clay soling, long-distance alignments in this part of the region were generally levelled tracks whose width is likely to have depended upon the terrain and on what was considered sufficient to facilitate movement.[12] In the hilly areas—comprising part of the terrain in Ashoka's traverse across Central India—were narrow passageways created by cutting through rocky areas. Ashoka is unlikely to have begun the trek before the monsoon months because travel over this time was specially difficult. The Damoh area in Central India, for instance, which falls along his route, could not have been crossed with wheeled conveyances between July and October, its soil being black loam which became soggy to the point of stickiness after the first rains. Whatever the weather, the pragmatic option would have been pack animals and carts, not elephants. We also know from the accounts of later travellers that one of the major problems was to harmonize different modes of transport. Oxen and elephants move at a different pace. Jean Deloche, the historian of early transport and communication in India, provides a seventeenth-century travel account highlighting the trouble with heterogeneous groupings:

> Camels, pack oxen and oxen harnessed to the heavy carts of Hindusthan did not proceed at the same rate. When, in addition, it was necessary to adapt to the pace of light equipages of some wealthy patron travelling with swift elephants, only deplorable contretemps could result. To give a vivid example, we relate here the experience of Peter Mundy, who in 1633 had been charged to conduct the last caravan of the season, consisting of 268 camels and 109 carts, from Agra to Surat. Underway Mundy encountered the new governor of Gujarat, Baqir Khan, who was journeying to his residency along with his entourage, and asked to accompany him in the hope that he would thus avoid payment of local taxes and thereby reduce the transport expenses. The decision proved to be imprudent and costly. The troubles soon began. It was impossible for Mundy's caravan to keep pace with the fast rhythm of the official escort. At Khamva, a sand-storm broke, followed by